

A Guide to Open Source Project Servers

In the first part of this series of articles, we looked at desktop project management tools like MS Project. In this second part, we will look at project servers like MS Project Server.



Desktop project management tools are easy to install and hardly need any maintenance. However, every team member has to install them on his or her desktop. The project plan has to be updated by one person, typically, the project manager (PM) and shared with the team, leadership and stakeholders. Though in theory this update can be done on a daily basis, it gets done less often as it is very laborious. As a result of this built-in delay in knowing the status, corrective action can be delayed by a few days. Wouldn't it be nice if there was a single instance of the up-to-date status that could be updated by every team member and visible to all? Yes, there is — and that is what is popularly known as a project server.

Setting up a project server is not so simple

Installing the desktop project management software is as simple as

downloading an app from a website and double-clicking it. However, for installing a project server, typically, you will have to follow a set of instructions to get the software installed in a shared server at your hosting provider or in your cloud account. To understand the instructions, someone in your team needs to be familiar with Linux, MySQL database, Apache Web server, and so on. You can, of course, hire a contractor to do the initial installation. However, make sure to assign one tech-savvy member of your team to shadow that work and keep notes, and also get trained in daily operations such as data backup and checking error logs as well as ongoing maintenance work such as patching and upgrades.

The benefit is that once you have gone through the painful process of installing and configuring a project server, you can simply give Web based access to all the team members as well as your company leadership to share

the project status and view reports. That doesn't mean everyone can see everything. You can grant role based access to screens and reports.

Security is a big concern

When you make your company's application accessible from any browser, it is very convenient. Employees can access it from the field, while travelling, or while working from home (WFH). But then it also opens a way for hackers to try to break into your systems. You may think that it is not a big problem if hackers are able to access your project plan. However, if they can get access to your project server, that will give them an entry point to access other servers that may have more sensitive financial or intellectual property (IP) data or make your company vulnerable to a ransomware attack. So, pay attention to security, especially if this is the first Web based app you are deploying.